

8. Agent Assistants

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From a Tool to a Teammate

A research team

- Many agents, different roles, working together
- They propose, attack, verify, and re-check each other

A personal assistant

- One agent that carries work across sessions
- Remembers context, uses your tools, acts on your behalf

Draft outline — the two shapes below are where agents pay off: a *panel* that pressure-tests ideas, and an *assistant* that just gets things done.

A Research Team

Many Roles, One Question

Debate

- A proposer generates ideas; an adversary attacks them
- Disagreement surfaces the weak points early

Ground it

- A verifier checks claims against your own library
- An analyst builds the data and runs the empirics

Check it

- A replicator re-derives the result independently
- Two paths to the same number, or a red flag

The coauthor skill orchestrates this. *Placeholder: walk one round of propose — attack — verify.*

Personal Assistants

An Agent That Carries the Work

- Give it a goal, not a script; it plans the steps
- It uses tools — files, code, the web — to act
- State persists, so today's work builds on yesterday's
- *Placeholder: a standing assistant for a recurring task*

What Makes It an Agent

Not just answering

- It decides *what to do next*, then does it
- It checks its own output and retries

Kept in bounds

- You choose which tools it may use
- You review before anything irreversible

Why This Belongs at the End

Everything so far was you **directing a tool**. An agent is you **delegating a task** — which means the new skills are describing the goal well and judging the result.

Breakout

Questions to Discuss

- What recurring task would you hand to a standing assistant first?
- For a research question in your field, what roles would your ideal agent team have?
- What tools would you *withhold* from an agent working on real data?
- Where is the line between useful delegation and losing track of what was done?